

The Terms

The names of games, dynasties and seventeenth-century antiquaries that Falkener assumes you already know.

Falkener writes for readers he assumes share his shelf. He uses the names of games, of dynasties, of seventeenth-century antiquaries and of Egyptological apparatus without stopping, and the modern names for several of these things have since changed. Both are given here.

Where a term is the subject of a reconstruction rather than a report, the entry says so.

sent sen't; senet	The word written in hieroglyphs over the draught-board in the tomb scenes, and the name of the principal Egyptian game. Birch warned Falkener that it is written without a determinative and is therefore <i>very ambiguous</i> , and suggested it might connect with <i>sen</i> , a robber — which is where Falkener's title <i>The Game of Robbers</i> comes from. The game is what is now called senet .
Senat	Falkener's name for the shorter game of section V, played on a board of five squares each way — not the twelve-square board of section IV with fewer men on it. The spelling is his; modern usage does not separate it from senet as a distinct named game.
Tau	The Egyptian game of section IV, and the volume's central subject. The OCR of the scan repeatedly proposed reading this as <i>Tan</i> ; the printed page reads TAU, and the correction was refused. See the note on the text.
Hab em han the game of the jar; the game of the bowl	The name Birch read over the circular board — the game of the jar, or as Falkener prefers, of the bowl, because the picture shows a bowl. The board is a set of concentric rings of cells with a vessel at the centre.
Mehen	The modern name for the circular-board game of section VI: <i>the coiled one</i> , after the serpent deity who wraps around the sun god on his passage through the night. It belongs to the Predynastic period and the Old Kingdom. Falkener does not use the word; the identification is this edition's, and it is offered as an identification rather than as something he says.
Ludus latruncolorum ludus calculorum; latrunculi	The Roman game of the little robbers, known from Latin poets who describe pieces being blocked and surrounded. Falkener's claim is that it is the Egyptian game under a Latin name, which is why sections IV's running head alternates between the two. Specialists today treat it as its own game.
Latrunculi	The pieces in that game — literally the little robbers or brigands. Falkener quotes Bulengerus, one of his seventeenth-century authorities, as saying they were so called on account of their impudence.
Kelbs	Dogs. The word Falkener reports Egyptian players using in his own century for the men, when playing without a board by scooping holes in the ground and using stones, beads or beans. He notes the Greeks used the same word for the men in the game of robbers — one of the more solid observations in the volume, because it is reported rather than reconstructed.
Astragals knucklebones	Knucklebones, thrown as dice are thrown. Falkener has the pieces in the game of the bowl enter by the throw of astragals; that they were used is his inference from the game being played for money, not something the sources record.
Determinative	In Egyptian writing, an unspoken sign added to a word to indicate what class of thing it belongs to. Its absence is why Birch could not settle what <i>sent</i> meant, and why he told Falkener so.
Fourth dynasty	The Egyptian dynasty of the great pyramid builders, to which Falkener traces the games. He declines to date it, leaving that, he says, to Egyptian chronologists — a restraint worth noticing in a book otherwise happy to reconstruct.
Beni-Hassan	The Middle Egyptian cemetery whose twelfth-dynasty tombs carry several of the painted gaming scenes Birch describes: the low table of painted wood, the men set at each end of the board with a space between.
Hatasu Hatshepsut	The queen now usually called Hatshepsut, whose bust in the Berlin Museum supplied the illustration on the 1892 book's front cover, and whose draught-board Falkener describes. He places her about 1600 BC.
Thoth Hermes	The Egyptian god of writing and reckoning, identified by the Greeks with Hermes, and credited in the myth Falkener cites with inventing the game of draughts. A myth of invention is evidence of how a game was regarded, not of how it was played.

Samuel Birch		1813–1885. The British Museum’s leading Egyptologist, Keeper at the British Museum from the 1861 division of the department of antiquities — of the Oriental, British and Mediaeval Antiquities at first, and of Oriental Antiquities alone after the further subdivision of 1866, so he was already three years a Keeper when he wrote to Falkener in 1864, and founder of the Society of Biblical Archaeology in 1870. The paper he wrote for Falkener in 1864 is printed in section II and is the best evidence in this volume. Falkener calls him founder of the Society, which he was — but from six years after the letter.
Gnossus Knossos		The Cretan city, on whose coins the circular labyrinth appears. Birch notes the resemblance between that labyrinth and the arrangement of the circular board, which is an observation about shape and is not an argument for a connection.
Salmasius, Bulengerus	Hyde,	Three of the seventeenth- and eighteenth-century antiquaries whose works Falkener lists at the head of section IV — Salmasius 1620, Bulengerus 1627, Hyde 1694. They are the scholarship he means when he says the bones of the skeleton had been assembled and the game still not played.
Tabula		The Roman board, and the name of a game on it; it appears in the Latin verse Falkener renders freely as an invitation to move the sly latrunculi when the studious hours have tired you.
Draught-board		Falkener’s habitual English for the Egyptian gaming board — a rectangular grid of cells. The term imports the assumption that the game resembled draughts, which is part of what he is trying to establish rather than something given.